

AIRPORT DEVICE HANDLING PROTOCOL

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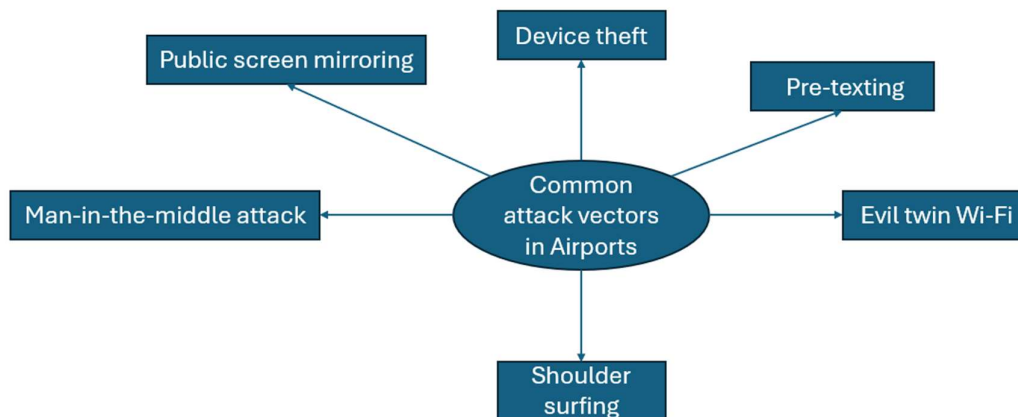
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Introduction

This airport device handling protocol is designed to aid users in protecting their devices and maintain OPSEC within airport environments. This protocol was mainly developed as sometimes attackers may attempt compromise devices or accounts in airport environments. This protocol was also made to aid those with nation-state actors to protect their devices and maintaining OPSEC while traveling or in the case of being forced to hand over devices. Some common attack vectors that attackers use in airport environments are MITM attacks, Device theft, and Shoulder surfing. For those with nation-state actors as their threat model the common attack vectors are Juice Jacking (Malicious charging stations) , Forced handover (Legally take your device) and use Wi-Fi logs (They can legally get logs or compromise the airport's Wi-Fi provider).

This airport device handling protocol cannot provide perfect OPSEC or security during any time of your journey. However, this protocol can increase your security in airport environments and prepare those with nation-state actors for situations such as forced handover. Make sure to remember that forced handover is for those with nation-state actors only and should only be prepared for if certain of nation-states as a threat model. Do not blindly trust this protocol as your only protection. Make sure to adapt this protocol based on your own devices and threat model.



The spider diagram shows 6 of the most common vectors used by attackers within airport environments. This diagram doesn't show nation-state attack vectors as most people don't have nation-state actors as their threat model. If you do have nation-state actors as your threat model, make sure to refer to the introduction above or do your own research on their attack vectors.

Main Journey Section

- This section is for the main parts of your airport journey which includes steps inside and outside the airport.
- This section will be enough for most users as attackers don't normally target people in airport environments often.
- For those with nation-state actors as their threat model, I would suggest reading this section and the forced handover session for full understanding.
- This section will use the example of a user with the latest iPhone and Windows 11 Home Operating System.
- This protocol contains 3 main layers for this section
- Each layer is equally important for securing your devices and maintaining OPSEC
- The first step is preparation
- This is where you prepare the devices you are carrying, perform backups and make sure the journey plan is clear
- The user in this situation may enable device encryption and create backups of their most sensitive data
- These backups should be stored encrypted and within multiple locations
- This step is important to ensure that you do not lose all your data in the case of device theft.
- The second step is getting through security
- This step means attempting to get through airport security without any issues
- This can be done by shutting down devices, taking off anything metal and staying calm throughout the process
- This step is important as security has no reason to stop you and you can quickly and securely move to the next part of your journey.
- The final step is staying secure post-security
- This step means making sure that your device or accounts aren't compromised before you get onto the flight.
- This can be done by using VPNs, muscle memory for locking devices, encrypted DNS and situational awareness
- This step is important to ensure that you aren't easily compromised after passing through security.
- Make sure to adapt this section as needed to your own resources, tool and journey.

Forced Handover Section

- This section was made specifically for the case of where you are legally forced to hand over your devices.
- This section is only for those with nation-state actors as their threat model as they have the legal authority to take your devices.
- The purpose of this section is not to prevent the handover itself but instead to perform damage control.
- The first step is to calm down
- This can be done by taking a few deep breathes
- This step is important as staying calm in this situation is the best possible action you can take
- The second step is to make sure to identify the legal reason for having to handover your devices
- This step can be done by asking for names, badge numbers or other information to build a legal case if needed.
- This step is important to legally defend yourself against nation-state actors as even they aren't fully immune to the law
- The third step is to assume breach of your devices
- This can be done by changing passwords, burning accounts and rotating encryption keys if necessary.
- This step is important as nation-state actors are likely to be able to compromise your device with time and resources
- The fourth step is recovering your devices
- This step can be done through legal processes like having a lawyer or having evidence that your devices were taken for no reason at all
- However, be warned that you may need to cleanly install the operating system and check for hardware implants such as keyloggers.
- The final step is to document the process
- This step means making sure to note down securely how you got through the forced handover or what was lost
- You can use the structure What (What devices were taken?) → Why (Why were they taken?) → Response (How did you respond to the handover?) → Recovery (Did you get your devices back?) → Potential improvements (What could be improved for next time?)
- Remember that these steps can only raise the cost for a nation-state actor and mainly focus on damage control instead of prevention.
- Make sure to adapt this section to your needs, resources and the airport you are going to as legal authority and enforcement vary across countries.

Airport Device Handling Protocol Trade-offs

- This airport device handling protocol has trade-offs just like any other system I have made so far.
- I have identified 4 main trade-offs with this protocol.
- The first trade-off is time-consumption.
- This trade-off exists because preparation and execute can be time-consuming and require situational awareness for long durations.
- This means that users may struggle to prepare or execute this protocol for the long duration of the journey and staying in the airport.
- This trade-off can be managed by planning your journey in advance, having a friend or family member with you for company and doing fun activities on your devices to pass time.
- The second trade-off is risk of paranoia.
- This trade-off exists because constantly observing your surroundings expecting a threat can make you paranoid.
- This means that users may become paranoid in every airport environment or in daily life which is not sustainable at all.
- This trade-off can be managed by staying aware in more threatening environments like security and using calming techniques to relax yourself.
- The third trade-off is cost.
- This trade-off exists as having backup infrastructure, the journey itself, security infrastructure and legal infrastructure can be expensive.
- This means that users may not want to follow the protocol or may not even be able to afford it.
- This trade-off can be managed by using free security and backup tools, built-in security features and layering protections based on your threat model.
- The fourth trade-off is law immunity.
- This trade-off exists as nation-state actors can act in national security interests and seize your device without a way for you to fight back easily.
- This means that users with a nation-state actors threat model may lose their devices and have their data compromised.
- This trade-off can be managed by using the steps in my forced handover section, not bringing all your devices and avoiding airports or nation-state-controlled areas where possible.
- It is important to remember that in some countries the law cannot save you as some countries are ruled by dictatorships and do not need to obey the law at all.